

When I was born, the world human population stood at a little over 2.7 billion. In the time I have been alive it has increased to over 7.2 billion and there is no doubt that this dramatic increase has caused the web of life to fray considerably. Wilderness areas have reduced by almost half, and many species are now threatened. Not just the countless tiny creatures that live in the undergrowth, but primates like us, 50 percent of which are already in danger. Anxiety about species losses is rightly growing, but consider the bigger picture. The norm for any species on our planet is extinction and it has been estimated that only about 1 percent of all species that have ever lived are alive today. The evolution of life on earth has been shaped over thousands of millions of years by numerous extinction events, some so large that relatively few species survived them. We and all other species are descendants of those survivors. But now the earth faces an extinction event caused primarily by human numbers and activities. Unchecked, the loss of natural habitat may lead to the extinction of one third of all living species in the next hundred years.

We are now asking questions that I never imagined would be asked when I was studying Zoology—which species to save and which species we can let go. It's a bit like saying—there are 200 species of owls but we may have to lose half of them. How do you choose which ones we need to look after and which ones we can let slip into oblivion? We might try to conserve “one-of-a-kind” species, organisms that are so unique and genetically different from everything else that they deserve special treatment. Or you could take a different approach and concentrate on preserving the species that have an intrinsic value to us—the ones that provide us with food and materials. The trouble is we know so little about the complexities of ecosystems that we might very well get it wrong. Surely it would be much better to try to save as much of the natural habitat that remains as we possibly can.

Studying the natural world is one of the most absorbing and satisfying things anyone can do and if I had my life over again I would still want to spend it getting to know some of the animals I might encounter.



George McGavin
Zoologist, explorer, and broadcaster

